

ORVILLE WRIGHT'S ARMY TRIALS

WHILE WILBUR WAS DEMONSTRATING in Europe, Orville prepared for the all-important US Army tests, arriving in Fort Myer, Virginia, on August 20, 1908. During September, Orville and his Military Flyer set nine new world records, including two for altitude and one for endurance (flying for just under an hour).

However, disaster struck on September 17, when Orville took an official army passenger, Lieutenant Thomas Selfridge, for a ride. On his fourth circuit, he heard a tapping noise, followed by two loud bangs, announcing the loss of a faulty propeller. Orville lost control of the airplane and it smashed into the ground, crumpling into a twisted wreck. Selfridge died a few hours later from a fractured skull. Orville was lucky to escape with serious injuries, including a fractured thigh, broken ribs, and serious scalp wounds.

FIRST CASUALTY

When Thomas Selfridge became the first person to die (right) in a powered aircraft, safety straps had not yet been thought of. Pilots and passengers simply grabbed one of the wing struts to keep themselves on board.



them at the White House; senators adjourned the Senate so that they could see them fly when they came to Fort Myer to complete the army trials; and an estimated one million people turned out to watch Wilbur make a spectacular flight along the Hudson River. Yet amid this whirlwind of celebration and publicity, the Wrights were already showing signs of pulling back from the aviation circus. They refused to compete for the large cash prizes on offer for the first man to fly from London to Manchester, or across the Channel, showing a dislike of such publicity stunts. And in August 1909, the Wrights were the only significant fliers not to attend the Reims air meeting – a defining moment for the future of aviation (see pages 44–45). Instead they tried to put their aircraft manufacturing business onto a more solid footing.

In 1910, the Wright aircraft company was set up by a consortium that included some of the country's wealthiest businessmen, and a factory was opened in Dayton. In Europe, Wright flying machines were made by a number of companies under license. But despite successful new models such as the Baby Wright racer, the Wrights soon ceased to be market leaders, for instead of concentrating their efforts on the development of

